Khurasan, who had come to visit his son in Hindustan. Both ‘father and son’, writes Abul Fazl, ‘were encompassed with favours’. Then, for no clearly stated reason, Sharafuddin ran away. Akbar heard the news of his sudden and suspicious departure with ‘complete surprise and amazement’; Abul Fazl writes that Akbar often spoke of how his kin’s ‘narrow capacity could not stand’ his patronage.

He went westwards, beaten out of Rajasthan by Husain Quli Khan, Bairam’s nephew, the young man whom Akbar had once disparaged for not having fought so much as a chicken. Sharafuddin may have hoped to find refuge in the independent kingdom of Gujarat, which would shelter many rebel chiefs in the years to come. On his way, as luck would have it, Sharafuddin met the very first disgruntled nobleman of Akbar’s reign, Shah Abul Ma’ali, favourite of Humayun. Released by Bairam Khan during the upheavals that unseated the regent, Abul Ma’ali was imprisoned by Akbar once again, and exiled to Mecca to mend his ways. When Sharafuddin met him, the handsome sayyid had just returned to Hindustan, his malevolence intact.

Sharafuddin and Abul Ma’ali concocted a plan. Abul Ma’ali would lead a contingent of men against Husain Quli Khan in Rajasthan, then proceed to Kabul, from where he would extract Akbar’s half-brother, the young Mirza Muhammad Hakim, and bundle him across the Indus – the first of many times that Hakim would be dreamt of as an alternative to his intransigent older brother. Sharafuddin’s contribution to the effort, rather more vaguely described, would be to ‘do all he could to promote a rebellion’.[10]

Abul Ma’ali’s offensive against Husain Quli and others loyal to Akbar was an utter failure, and it wasn’t long before the ‘wicked . . . one’[11] was winding his way through byways and hidden tracks to Kabul, no longer in search of a new king but rather of refuge. Before his temporary disappearance from the tale, however, Abul Ma’ali took one last shot – literally – at destroying the young padishah under whose rule the proud sayyid’s flourishing career was so abruptly forestalled.

He hired an assassin.

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In the winter of 1563, Akbar was hunting in Mathura when he heard that